A New Short Film Joins My Chemical Romance's World

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Self-taught artist Lauren Tsai first introduced the **uncanny dreamscape** of The Dying World with a short film at the Annecy Film Festival last year, then showed it in her solo exhibition at the Hollywood Forever Cemetery, which ended last November. Now she has returned with a My Chemical Romance collaboration, a full-circle moment for the artist who as a kid made animated fan videos for the band's songs.

The short film, Prelude to The End, continues the story of the character Astrid while deepening the **narrative** of The Dying World with new voices, additional characters and settings. Tsai called it an absolute dream to work on the project for The Black Parade and The Dying World, saying she deeply respects the band and Gerard's creative legacy, and that it is an honor he found inspiration in a world she created.

Prelude to The End arrives on the heels of last Friday's release of The Black Parade (20th Anniversary), the landmark rock opera by the Jersey pop-punkers, considered highly influential in the emo genre. The film will screen ahead of the final dates of the band's five-night run at the Hollywood Bowl on Oct. 30 and 31.

The collaboration is **soundtracked** by the album's first song, The End. Astrid navigates a **peculiar** New England boarding school overrun by trash. When school authorities toss her cherished sketchbook down a chute, she follows it into a world of forgotten ideas and meets an old friend from her previous film, The Dying World Part One: Forgetting. The film explores our relationships with our creations, youth and the determination to express our truth, a recurring theme in the band's **catalog**.

In addition to Tsai voicing Astrid, the film features vocal contributions from Billie Eilish as Astrid's friend, Phoebe Bridgers as Astrid's sister, Hideo Kojima as The Teacher and John C. McGinley as The Dean. The short also includes a live recording of Pascal Dusapin's Flying River, Violin Concerto, performed by Utopia Orchestra.

Word Treasure

uncanny -- Strange in a way that feels a little unsettling, as if something is not quite normal.
dreamscape -- A place or scene that feels like it comes from a dream.
narrative -- The story of something, and the order in which its events happen.
soundtracked -- Given music to go with it, as a film is given songs or music.
catalog -- All the songs or works that a band or artist has made.
peculiar -- Strange or unusual, different from what you would expect.

Background you need

A short film tells a complete story in a much shorter time than a full-length film, often by focusing on one character and one striking idea.

My Chemical Romance are a rock band whose album The Black Parade is a rock opera, meaning it tells a connected story across its songs.

Lauren Tsai created her own dream world, The Dying World, and has already told part of its story through an earlier short film.

This new film brings those two worlds together: it continues the story of Tsai's character Astrid, set to music from the band's album.

Break it down

LEAD: Lauren Tsai has returned with a My Chemical Romance collaboration, a full-circle moment for the artist who made animated fan videos for the band as a kid.

KEY EVENT: The short film Prelude to The End continues Astrid's story and deepens The Dying World.

+- WHO: Self-taught artist Lauren Tsai, with voices from Billie Eilish, Phoebe Bridgers, Hideo Kojima and John C. McGinley.

+- WHAT: Astrid follows her sketchbook down a chute into a world of forgotten ideas and meets an old friend.

+- WHEN: Screening ahead of the band's final Hollywood Bowl dates on Oct. 30 and 31, after last Friday's release of The Black Parade (20th Anniversary).

BACKGROUND: Tsai first introduced The Dying World in a short film at the Annecy Film Festival last year, then showed it in a solo exhibition at the Hollywood Forever Cemetery.

THEME: The film explores our relationships with our creations, youth and the determination to express our truth.

Why it matters

The collaboration shows how a fan's homemade tribute can grow into a professional partnership, and how music and film can join to carry a story -- and its themes of creativity and self-expression -- to a much wider audience.

Test what you remember

1. What is the new short film called?

- (A) The Dying World Part One: Forgetting
- (B) Flying River
- (C) Prelude to The End
- (D) The Black Parade

2. Who made animated fan videos for the band's songs as a kid?

- (A) Phoebe Bridgers
- (B) Billie Eilish
- (C) Hideo Kojima
- (D) Lauren Tsai

3. Which song soundtracks the collaboration?

- (A) A song written by Billie Eilish
- (B) The first song of the album, The End
- (C) Flying River, Violin Concerto
- (D) A song from The Dying World Part One

4. When will the film screen ahead of the band's final Hollywood Bowl dates?

- (A) At the Annecy Film Festival last year
- (B) Last November
- (C) Last Friday
- (D) Oct. 30 and 31

5. What happens to Astrid's sketchbook in the story?

- (A) School authorities toss it down a chute
- (B) It is lost at the Hollywood Bowl
- (C) She leaves it at boarding school
- (D) She gives it to her sister

6. Who voices Astrid's sister?

- (A) Lauren Tsai
- (B) Billie Eilish
- (C) John C. McGinley
- (D) Phoebe Bridgers

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Lauren Tsai: She called it an absolute dream to work on the project, saying she deeply respects the band and Gerard's creative legacy and that it is an honor he found inspiration in a world she created.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):